

2.2 Common Pitfall: Why Natural-Language Descriptions Fail

Before applying the modifiers, confirm you are not defaulting to the broken approach. Read the diagnosis below and check whether your current prompting style matches the failure pattern.

The Failure Pattern: You type descriptions like "sound clipped," "be sardonic," or "use short sentences" and expect the AI to restructure its output. The AI interprets these as stylistic suggestions layered over its default architecture. It changes the paint color. It does not rewire the plumbing.

The Diagnostic Test: If your correction prompt contains any of the following, it is operating at the paint level rather than the architecture level:

- ☐ Emotional adjectives without structural constraints ("sound grumpier," "be more sarcastic")
- ☐ Vague length instructions without variance rules ("use short sentences")
- ☐ Tone requests without temperature settings ("make it colder")
- ☐ Style descriptions without turn-taking choreography ("he's the kind of guy who interrupts")

The Fix: Turn every plain-language description into two parts: a named modifier and a measurable constraint. For example, a vague note like "sound clipped" can become "Rhythm Lock: Alternate between two-word fragments and one controlled sentence of twelve to fifteen words." The measurable constraint has final authority over the default setting. The description sits above it, adding helpful context without changing the rule.